

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Extreme cold

NATURAL HAZARDS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Get into a warm, dry place, replace wet clothing and add dry layers. Confusion, extreme drowsiness or loss of coordination can indicate hypothermia; call emergency services. Use safe heat and never bring grills or generators indoors.

Do now.

**Get sheltered**

01

Limit outdoor exposure and protect hands, feet, head and face.

**Change wet clothing**

02

Use dry layers and blankets; warm the body gently.

**Find safe heat**

03

Use approved heaters as directed, keep them away from combustibles and maintain CO alarms.

**Arrange help**

04

If heat fails, contact local warming shelters and help people with limited mobility relocate safely.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Use one dry room, layered clothing, blankets and insulation beneath you. Keep fuel-burning outdoor equipment outside. If you cannot keep people warm, identify a reachable warm place before they become confused or weak; do not wait for a warming centre to open.

Watch for.

Do not rub frostbitten skin or apply direct intense heat.

People & practical needs.

Check children, older adults and people with limited movement rather than relying only on their report that they feel fine. Keep dry layers and a reachable warmer location in the plan. Protect medicine and mobility equipment from temperature damage according to their instructions.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Keep medicines, transport and backup plans ready. Watch for numb, pale or waxy skin that may signal frostbite.

Check the next usable option

Keep medicines, transport and backup plans ready. Watch for numb, pale or waxy skin that may signal frostbite.

When the first option is unavailable

Use one dry room, layered clothing, blankets and insulation beneath you. Keep fuel-burning outdoor equipment outside. If you cannot keep people warm, identify a reachable warm place before they become confused or weak; do not wait for a warming centre to open.

Questions in the field.

Why does wet clothing matter?

Wet and wind-exposed clothing can accelerate heat loss. Move to a sheltered warmer place when safe and change wet layers using what is available. Avoid unvented fuel-burning appliances, generators or outdoor cooking equipment for indoor heat.

What if someone becomes confused or drowsy?

Treat serious cold-related changes as a medical emergency, reduce further heat loss and handle the person gently. Follow reachable clinical guidance rather than making them walk to warm up or giving an unconscious person a drink.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Extreme cold · official guidance

<https://www.weather.gov/safety/cold>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/extreme-cold/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.